

COMPLETED NOVEL

The Observation Target

The Erasure Log

sci-fi · melancholic · en

Tokyo is a blur of charcoal grey and neon bleeding into wet asphalt. Ren Kanzaki walks through the rain, his umbrella a fragile shield against a sky that feels too heavy, as if the atmosphere itself has become porous. He does not remember why he is returning to the university at midnight, only that there is a persistent, humming void in his chest that demands to be filled.

The research building is a monolith of concrete and silence. Inside, the air is sterile, smelling of ozone and the metallic tang of cooling fans. As he descends into the quantum computing laboratory, the silence shifts; it becomes a physical weight, pressing against his eardrums. This is his place of work, yet as he passes the rows of white-lit workstations and cold steel surfaces, he feels like a trespasser in his own life.

He stops before a heavy oak desk—an anachronism in a room full of liquid-cooled servers. It belonged to Professor Kuon. The professor has been gone for days, a disappearance that should feel like a crisis, but in Ren's mind, it is merely another gap, another missing piece of a puzzle he cannot remember how to solve.

Ren's hand trembles slightly as he reaches for the bottom drawer. It is locked. He finds the key taped to the underside of the desk, a hiding place so cliché it feels like a joke, yet the act of unlocking it feels like a transgression. The drawer slides open with a dry, rhythmic creak.

Inside, buried beneath a stack of obsolete hardware manuals, lies a physical logbook. Its cover is worn, the leather peeling at the edges. Ren flips through the pages. The handwriting is Kuon's—erratic, academic, descending into a frantic scrawl toward the end. Most of the notes are illegible, equations for quantum state mirroring that seem to fold into themselves, defying logic.

He reaches the final page. There is no equation here. Only a single, clinical sentence written in ink so black it looks like a tear in the paper:

“Ren Kanzaki will be removed from the observation target as of today.”

Ren stares at his name. The letters are familiar, but the context is alien. He feels a sudden, sharp surge of vertigo, as if the floor has tilted forty-five degrees. He is the target. He is the observation. The words do not offer a memory, only a definition of himself as a data point, a specimen to be discarded.

“Ren?”

He jolts, the logbook nearly slipping from his fingers. He turns to find Mio Shiraishi standing in the doorway. The fluorescent lights overhead flicker, casting a rhythmic, pale strobe across her face. She is wearing her white lab coat, her arms crossed tightly over her chest, as if she is trying to hold herself together.

“I didn’t think you’d be back tonight,” she says. Her voice is soft, but it lacks its usual warmth. It sounds thin, like a recording played at the wrong speed.

“Mio,” Ren says, his voice trailing off. He wants to ask her about the log. He wants to ask why his name is written like a death warrant in a professor’s diary. But as he looks at her, he notices that she isn’t looking at him. Her gaze is fixed somewhere just past his left shoulder, as if she is looking at a ghost or a smudge on the wall.

“You shouldn’t be in here,” she adds, her voice barely a whisper.

“Kurosaki said it was better if you just... rested. Until things stabilized.”

“Stabilized?” Ren asks. He takes a step toward her, the logbook still clutched in his hand. “What is happening, Mio? Why did Professor Kuon leave? Why is my name in this—”

Mio finally looks at him, but the expression in her eyes is not one of companionship. It is a mixture of profound pity and a terrifying, shimmering guilt. She flinches, a small, involuntary movement, and then steps back into the corridor, retreating from him as if he were a contagion.

“I can’t,” she says, her words fragmented. “I just... I can’t look at you right now.”

She turns and walks away, her footsteps echoing down the sterile hall until they are swallowed by the low, eternal hum of the servers. Ren stands alone in the white light, the rain still

drumming against the distant windows, holding a piece of paper that tells him he no longer exists in the eyes of the only man who knew what he was.